

Courtesy of University Archives (2)

Bill Stegmeier, crops breeder, explains advantages of growing pearl millet at a Hays field day.

Pearl Millet, Then and Now

Bill Stegmeier, an alternative crops researcher at the Fort Hays Branch Experiment Station (now the Agricultural Research Center–Hays), created a breeding program for pearl millet in the early '70s. Pearl millet was a staple food and feed crop in Africa and Asia.

Richard Vanderlip, emeritus professor of agronomy who worked with Stegmeier, said they wanted to see if the crop would work as an alternative to sorghum in the sandy soils of central Kansas.

According to *The First 100 Years, A History of the Agricultural Research Center–Hays*: By 1978, the breeding program was linked to international crop improvement programs, including the International Crops Institute for Semi-Arid Tropics (ICRISAT) headquartered in Hyderabad, India, and the International Sorghum and Millet Cooperative Research (INTSORMIL) program. That cooperation resulted in the exchange of several thousand varieties, germplasm lines, and elite inbred selections of pearl millet.

By 1997, at least half of the pearl millet hybrids marketed by India's private growers were produced using female parents from the Hays program … more than five million acres.

The Hays pearl millet program ended in 1999 but was revived in conjunction with the USAID Sorghum and Millet Innovation Lab. Desalegn Serba was hired as the millet breeder in 2016. The program develops genetically diverse parental lines that will produce high-yielding hybrids that withstand drought, high temperature, pests, and diseases.

Military Connections

To help military families, USDA and 4-H entered into a cooperative agreement with the U.S. Army Family and Child Services system. The goal was to create a 4-H club at each installation.

"The Army wanted to use 4-H because we had research-based material written to use in working with youth," said Marcia McFarland, 4-H Youth Development specialist.

The Air Force also implemented the project, and Navy/4-H programs were added in 2003.

In 2009, K-State Research and Extension initiated basic agriculture trainings for deploying soldiers from the Army's 1st Infantry Division at Fort Riley. From 2009 to 2011, four Kansas National Guard Agribusiness Development Teams attended trainings to prepare them for service in Laghman Province in Afghanistan.

The Larson Legacy

Vernon Larson became director of the Office of International Agricultural Programs in 1962 and added the title of K-State assistant provost for international programs in 1986.

Larson established formal relationships between K-State and universities and institutes in Paraguay, Costa Rica, Honduras, Mexico, France, China, and Botswana. He also helped form the Association of U.S. University Directors of International Agriculture Programs and the Mid-America International Agriculture Consortium.

An article from University Archives attributed to the KAES Editorial Office, provided this quote from Larson about how assignments overseas benefit Americans as well as the host countries.



Vernon Larson led international programs for 29 years, serving as director of the Office of International Agricultural Programs in the College of Agriculture and K-State's assistant provost for international programs.